

The Add-One Chain

A turn-taking talk game for circle time

? Ask

😊 Comment

💡 Add one

👂 Listen



Ages 3–7 · Preschool to Grade 2

Print · Project · Play

Prep: about 20 min, once · no-cut option

32

chain links

36

prompt cards

1-page

teacher script

7

circle-time games

+

family take-home

+

bonus story

Inside this kit

Teacher script (one page)	4
Our Add-One Chain wall poster	5
Chain-link strips (4 pages)	6
Name tags	10
Whose-turn tracker mat	11
Weekly turn tracker	12
Talking Star and “Chain tangle!” sign	13
Prompt and topic cards (4 pages)	14
Circle-time variations (2 pages)	18
Family take-home (2 pages)	20
Class certificate	22
Bonus read-aloud story	23
License terms and copyright	24

Also in your download

- **START HERE:** which file to open first
- **US Letter** and **A4** versions of this kit, each in **color** and **ink-saver** (white backgrounds, links to color in)
- **Slides** to project (16:9 PDF, 20 slides)
- **Bonus story:** *More Talk, Less Tap*, a 32-page read-aloud PDF

Quick start

1. **Print and cut** the chain-link strips (pages 6–9) and one set of prompt cards. About 20 minutes, once; a paper trimmer helps. For more than 16 children, print the link pages twice.
2. **Put up the poster** low, at children’s eye level, and tape the first link above it. Each new strip loops through the last link; a grown-up tapes the ends. Hang the chain along the wall as it grows.
3. **Read the teacher script** once (page 4).
4. **Play one round** at circle time. Count the chain together.

No time to cut? Project the slides and draw the chain on the board, one link per turn. You can play today.

How the game works

Every time a child asks, comments, adds one idea or shows they listened, a link goes on the class chain. Everyone builds **one chain together**. There are no winners, no points and no links taken away.



ASK a question to a friend



COMMENT something back to a friend



ADD ONE more idea to what a friend said



LISTEN and show you heard, your way

A first week with the Add-One Chain

Mon

Read the bonus story.
Meet the four links.

Tue

Your first round with
the teacher script.

Wed

Pass the Talking Star
(variation 1).

Thu

Add-One Story Chain
(variation 2).

Fri

Count the chain, sign
the certificate, send
the family page
home.

Before you start

Printing

- Print at **100% / actual size** so the cards line up. Choose US Letter or A4 to match your paper.
- **Cards:** white cardstock (about 65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) lasts longest. **Chain links** loop best on plain paper or light cardstock.
- **Laminate** the prompt cards if you will play all year, then round the corners. Print fresh links as the chain grows.
- **Save ink:** print the script, trackers and family pages in grayscale. Only the links and cards need color.
- **Print shop:** ask for “single-sided, full color, cardstock, no scaling”. Cut on the dashed lines.
- **Store** each card set in its own envelope or zip bag, labeled with its color.

Ages and groups

- **Ages 3–4:** start with COMMENT and LISTEN only. Rounds of 3–5 minutes. You read the cards aloud.
- **Ages 5–7:** use all four links and the prompt cards. Rounds of 8–10 minutes.
- Works for a whole class in a circle, a small group of 4–6, or pairs.
- The picture on every card carries its meaning, so pre-readers can play too.

Every way of talking counts

- Spoken words, signing, pointing, a picture card, a communication device, a nod or a thumbs-up all earn a link.
- Children may take their turn in the language they know best.
- “Pass” is always OK. A child who passes can still earn a LISTEN link.
- Count the class chain, never individual children. Links are never taken away.

Safety

- An adult leads and supervises every round.
- A grown-up does the taping. Keep tape, paper scraps and anything small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm) away from children under 3.
- The chain is a wall display: hang it high along the wall, never around anyone’s neck or across a walkway.
- Use painter’s tape or large hook-and-loop dots on the wall. Check dots before each play. Keep pushpins, staples and small magnets out of reach.
- For the Talking Star, use the paper star in this kit or a soft toy. For ball games, roll a soft, large ball along the floor.
- No balloons for children under 8.

This kit is a set of general classroom play ideas. It is not a program, assessment or screening tool, and it is not professional advice.

Why it works

Children get better at conversation by having lots of conversations: asking, answering, adding on and listening, with grown-ups and friends who wait for them. The chain makes each of those turns visible, so the whole class can see them and cheer. For the youngest, saying something back comes before asking a friend a question, so start there.

Three talk lines for any time

“Tell me more.”

“What happened next?”

“I wonder...”

Most classes love 2–3 of the six variations. Keep your favorites and skip the rest.

What you need

 Printed chain-link strips (pages 6–9)

 One set of prompt and topic cards

 The wall poster, clear tape and painter’s tape

 A basket, and the paper Talking Star or a soft toy

Optional: strips cut from scrap paper instead of printed ones, a cloth bag for Mystery Bag Talk, a soft ball for Comment Catch.

Teacher script: your first round

About 10 minutes (3–5 for ages 3–4, page 3) · whole group · say the words in bold quotes; do the gray notes

1

Gather 1 min

Children sit in a circle. The poster is up, the links and tape are in a basket, and the Talking Star is in your hand.

“Today we are going to make something by taking turns to talk. It is called the Add-One Chain!”

2

Meet the links 2 min

Hold up one link at a time.

“Blue means **ask: you ask a friend a question. Yellow means **comment**: you say something back. Green means **add one**: you add one more idea. Purple means **listen**: you show you heard your friend.”**

3

Show one turn 1 min

Play a turn with a child or another adult so everyone sees it first.

“What did you play today?” (Child answers.) “Me too! I love the sand table.” (Loop on a yellow link.) “My comment made our chain grow!”

4

Play the round 5 min

Draw a topic card and pass the star. After each turn, the child loops on a link and you tape it.

“Whoever holds the star takes a turn. Everyone else listens, their own way. You can ask, comment, add one, or say pass.”

5

Count and celebrate 1 min

Count the links together. Write the length on the tracker.

“Let’s count our chain: one, two, three... Our chain is ___ links long! We made that together, one turn at a time.”

If this happens...

Everyone talks at once

“Chain tangle! One voice at a time. Who has the star?” Hold up the tangle sign.

One child talks a lot

“Great idea! Hold it for the next round. Let’s hear from someone who hasn’t had a turn.”

A child needs to move

Let them stand or rock nearby. A moving body can still listen.

A child does not want a turn

“Pass is OK. You can point, nod or show me. Want to earn a listen link?”

The chain is short today

“Every link counts. We will add more tomorrow.”

The links run out

Print more, or add tally marks on the board.

Next time, try a variation from pages 18–19. The bonus story *More Talk, Less Tap* is a fun way to start on day one.

Our Add-One Chain

Every question, comment, idea and listening turn adds a link.



ASK

I asked a question.



COMMENT

I said something back.



ADD ONE

I added one more idea.



LISTEN

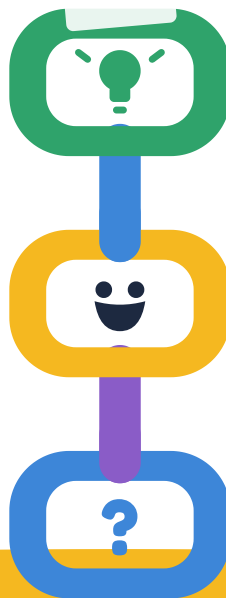
I listened to a friend.

One voice at a time

"Pass" is OK

Every way of talking
counts

We make one chain
together



Our chain starts above this poster. Watch it grow!

Chain links: ASK

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Plain paper or light cardstock. Loop each strip through the last link, then a grown-up tapes the two ends together. 8 per page: for more than 16 children, print it twice. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE

?

ASK

I asked a question.

name

TAPE
HERE

Chain links: COMMENT

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Plain paper or light cardstock. Loop each strip through the last link, then a grown-up tapes the two ends together. 8 per page: for more than 16 children, print it twice. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE
TAPE HERE		COMMENT I said something back.	name _____	TAPE HERE

Chain links: ADD ONE

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Plain paper or light cardstock. Loop each strip through the last link, then a grown-up tapes the two ends together. 8 per page: for more than 16 children, print it twice. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



ADD ONE
I added one more idea.

name _____

TAPE
HERE

Chain links: LISTEN

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Plain paper or light cardstock. Loop each strip through the last link, then a grown-up tapes the two ends together. 8 per page: for more than 16 children, print it twice. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

TAPE
HERE



LISTEN

I listened to a friend.

name

TAPE
HERE

Name tags

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Write one child's name on each tag and use them on the whose-turn mat (next page). Print this page once for every 12 children. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

name	name
name	name
name	name
name	name
name	name
name	name

No time to cut?

Write names straight into the **Ready for a turn** column of the whose-turn mat and tick each one after a turn, or use the weekly tracker (page 12).

Whose turn?

Stick every name tag in **Ready for a turn**. After a child's turn, they move their own name across. When every name has moved, the round is done: move them all back and start again.

?

Ready for a turn

Everyone starts here.

→

💡

Had a turn

Move your name here after your turn.

Tip: laminate this page and use hook-and-loop dots or painter's tape on the backs of the name tags. Check dots before each play. A child who passes still moves across: listening is a turn too. The mat holds 8 names, so use one per small group, or overlap the name tags for a whole class.

Add-One Chain turn tracker

Week of _____ · Color a square when a child adds that kind of link. Use it to make sure **everyone** gets a turn, never to rank or compare children. Keep it in your folder, not on the wall. Print two for a bigger class.

Name	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
Chain length	____ links	____ links	____ links	____ links	____ links

ask

comment

add one

listen

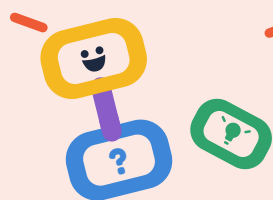
This is a play game, not a measurement or screening tool.

Talking Star and “Chain tangle!” sign

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Glue the star to cardstock; a craft-stick handle helps small hands. Whoever holds it takes a turn. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**



Talking Star



Chain tangle!

**One voice at a time.
Who has the star?**

Prompt cards: **ASK**

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. A grown-up reads it aloud. Children can change the words. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

? ASK What did you play today? ASK A FRIEND	? ASK What is your favorite animal? Why? ASK A FRIEND	? ASK If you could fly, where would you go? ASK A FRIEND
? ASK What makes you laugh? ASK A FRIEND	? ASK What would you like to build? ASK A FRIEND	? ASK Who do you like to play with? ASK A FRIEND
? ASK What is the best snack ever? ASK A FRIEND	? ASK What did you do this weekend? ASK A FRIEND	? ASK What would you do on a rainy day? ASK A FRIEND

Prompt cards: COMMENT

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. A grown-up reads it aloud. Children can change the words. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

 COMMENT Me too! I like... SAY SOMETHING BACK	 COMMENT Wow! I like that because... SAY SOMETHING BACK	 COMMENT That is so funny! SAY SOMETHING BACK
 COMMENT That reminds me of... SAY SOMETHING BACK	 COMMENT Cool! I didn't know that. SAY SOMETHING BACK	 COMMENT That sounds fun! SAY SOMETHING BACK
 COMMENT I think so too. SAY SOMETHING BACK	 COMMENT Oh! I would feel... SAY SOMETHING BACK	 COMMENT Nice idea! Maybe we could... SAY SOMETHING BACK

Prompt cards: **ADD ONE**

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. A grown-up reads it aloud. Children can change the words. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**

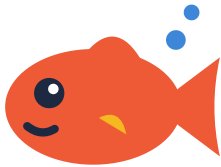
 ADD ONE And then... ADD ONE MORE	 ADD ONE Add one word: a big, big... ADD ONE MORE	 ADD ONE Add a color. ADD ONE MORE
 ADD ONE Add a sound. ADD ONE MORE	 ADD ONE Add a place: ...at the park. ADD ONE MORE	 ADD ONE Add who: ...with my friend. ADD ONE MORE
 ADD ONE Add a feeling: ... and I felt happy. ADD ONE MORE	 ADD ONE Add one more idea: We could also... ADD ONE MORE	 ADD ONE Add one more question. ADD ONE MORE

Topic cards

✂ Cut on the dashed lines. Draw one topic to start a round. **Grown-up keeps the pieces.**



TALK ABOUT



Pets and animals



TALK ABOUT



Food and snacks



TALK ABOUT



Weather



TALK ABOUT



Games we play



TALK ABOUT



Books and stories



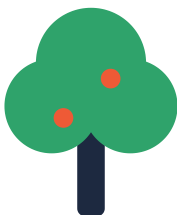
TALK ABOUT



At home



TALK ABOUT



Outside



TALK ABOUT



Songs and music



TALK ABOUT



Friends

Circle-time variations

Six more ways to grow the chain. Each one works with the same links, cards and rules, needs nothing to buy, and makes no mess.

1

Pass the Talking Star

Whole group · From 36 months · 5–10 min · **Prep:** none · **You need:** Talking Star, one topic card

1. Read the topic card aloud.
2. Pass the star around the circle. Whoever holds it may ask, comment, add one or pass.
3. Add a link after every turn and count the chain at the end.

2-minute version, no setup: Skip the topic card. Ask one question and pass the star to three children. One link each.

Make it easier: Everyone finishes the same starter: "I like..."

Make it harder: Each turn connects to the friend before: "Add one to what Maya said."

2

Add-One Story Chain

Whole group · From 48 months · 10 min · **Prep:** none · **You need:** Green links (for a whole class, print page 8 twice)

1. Start a silly story: "Once there was a dog who wanted to..."
2. Each child adds one thing to the story, and a green link goes on the chain.
3. At the end, retell the whole story together, one link at a time.

2-minute version, no setup: Say one story starter. Three children add one word each, then say the whole line together.

Make it easier: Add just one word each: "a big... red... bus".

Make it harder: Add a problem, then ask the circle how to fix it.

3

Ask Me One More

Pairs · From 48 months · 5 min · **Prep:** none · **You need:** Nothing at all

1. One partner shares something: "I have a cat."
2. The other listens, then asks one more question: "What is its name?"
3. Swap. Each pair adds a blue link to the class chain.

2-minute version, no setup: One pair shows the class: one shares, one asks one more question. Everyone cheers their way: clap, wave or a silent cheer.

Make it easier: Hand the asker an ASK card to read or point to.

Make it harder: Try for three questions in a row on the same topic.

Circle-time variations (continued)

4

Comment Catch

Small group · From 42 months · 5 min · **Prep:** find a soft ball · **You need:** A large soft ball

1. Sit in a small circle. One child shares a sentence about the topic.
2. Roll the ball along the floor to a friend.
3. The catcher makes a comment about what they heard, then shares their own sentence and rolls on.

2-minute version, no setup: No ball: point to a friend instead of rolling. Two or three turns.

Make it easier: Keep a COMMENT card in the middle to point to.

Make it harder: The catcher starts with the sharer's name: "Leo, that is funny!"

5

Listening Chain

Whole group · From 42 months · 5 min · **Prep:** none · **You need:** Purple links (for a whole class, print page 9 twice)

1. A child shares one thing about their day.
2. The next child says back one thing they heard, then shares their own.
3. Every say-back earns a purple link. A calm way to end a busy day.

2-minute version, no setup: You share one thing about your day. Two children say back what they heard.

Make it easier: The grown-up says it back first, then invites a child to try.

Make it harder: Say back two things you heard.

6

Mystery Bag Talk

Small group · From 36 months · 10 min · **Prep:** 1 min to fill the bag · **You need:** A cloth bag and one classroom object

1. Hide one object in the bag. Pick something too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube.
2. Children ask questions to guess it: "Is it soft?" Each question adds a blue link.
3. Reveal it, then everyone comments or adds one idea about it.

2-minute version, no setup: No bag: hold one classroom object behind your back and take three guesses.

Make it easier: Answer with a yes or no, and let children feel the bag.

Make it harder: The child who guesses hides the next object and answers the questions.

Keep it a celebration. Count the class chain, not individual turns. No winners, no prizes, and no child is made to talk before they are ready.

Play the Add-One Chain at home

Dear families,

This week our class played **the Add-One Chain**, a talk game where every question, comment and idea adds a link to our class paper chain. Our chain grew to _____ links! Here is how to play at home. You need no screens and nothing special.

How to play (5 minutes)

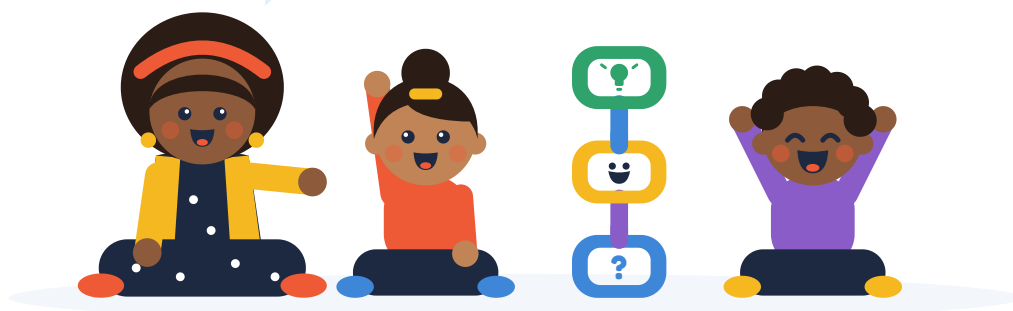
1. **Pick a moment:** dinner, the car, bath time or a walk.
2. **Pick a topic:** food, animals, today, a silly “what if”.
3. **Take turns:** ask a question, say something back, or add one more idea.
4. **Build:** every turn adds a link. Tape strips of scrap paper into a chain, or color a link on the sheet we sent home.
5. **Count** your chain together at the end.

Tips for grown-ups

- **Pause and wait.** Count to five in your head after you ask.
- **Say what you see.** “You’re smiling! Is that a funny idea?”
- **Repeat and add one word.** “A dog!” “A *big* dog!”
- **Follow their lead.** Talk about what your child already loves.
- **Every way counts.** Pointing, signing, gestures and a tap on a talking device are turns too. A talking device is a child’s voice, not screen time.
- **Use your home language.** Talk, sing and read in the language you know best.

Safety: an adult plays along and does the taping. Keep tape and paper scraps away from babies and toddlers. Hang the chain up; it is never worn.

What did you play?



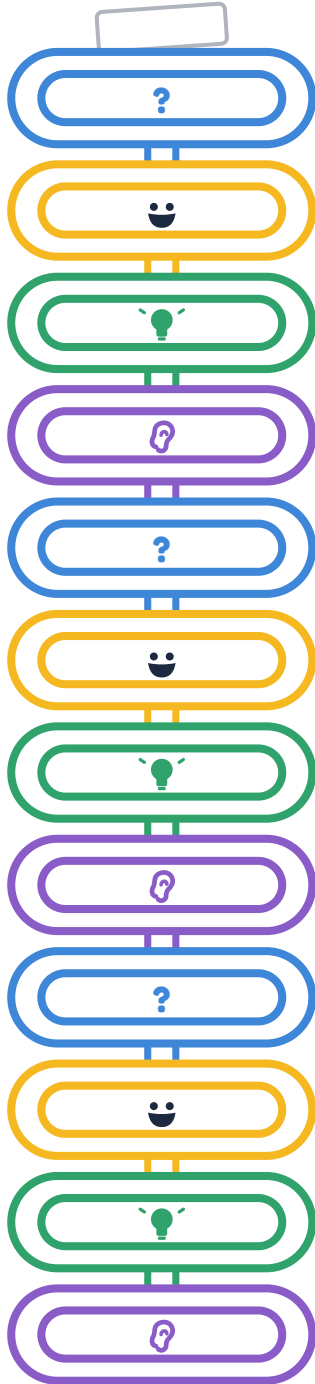
Free family bonus

More 5-minute talk games to print at home:
playbeforepixels.com/bonus/picture-more-talk-less-tap

From: _____
(teacher or group leader)

Our Family Add-One Chain

Color one link for every turn, starting at the top. Stick it on the fridge and see how long your chain grows this week!



? What did you play today?	? What is your favorite animal? Why?
? If you could fly, where would you go?	? What makes you laugh?
😊 Me too! I like...	😊 Wow! I like that because...
😊 That is so funny!	😊 That reminds me of...
💡 And then...	💡 Add one word: a big, big...
💡 Add a color.	💡 Add a sound.

Our chain was _____ links long!

Date: _____

Family photos of chains are always welcome. Please don't share children's names or faces online without permission.



ADD-ONE CHAIN CERTIFICATE

Our class made an Add-One Chain!

_____ links long

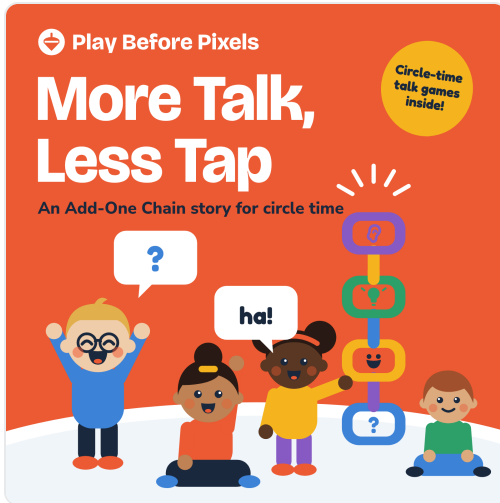
Class: _____

Date: _____ Teacher: _____

We asked questions, said things back, added big ideas and
listened to our friends, every way we talk.



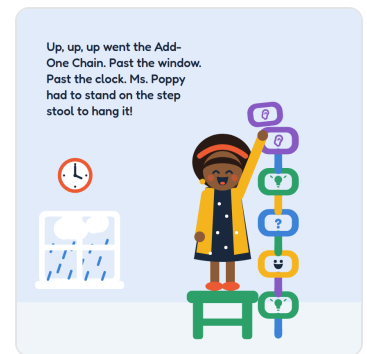
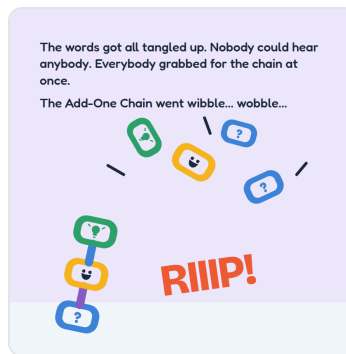
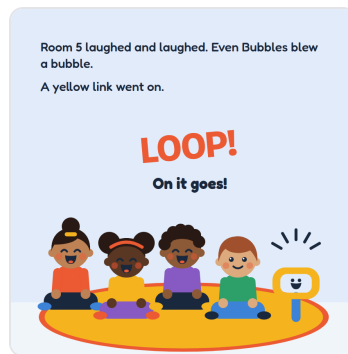
Bonus: the read-aloud story



More Talk, Less Tap is a 32-page picture-book story that comes free with this kit. Room 5 makes an Add-One Chain, one question, joke and idea at a time, until everybody talks at once and... RIIP! Quiet Sam has the idea that saves the day: take turns.

One difference: in the story, yellow links are for jokes and laughs. In the game, yellow means **comment**, saying something back to a friend. Laughing at a friend's joke still counts! And the "tap" in the title? It is the rain on the window and Bubbles the fish. A tap on a talking device is talk, and it always earns a link.

File: Add-One-Chain-Story-Read-Aloud.pdf (square pages). Project it for the group, or print it one or two pages per sheet.



Before

- Show the cover. "What do you think an Add-One Chain is?"
- Point to the four colors of links. Can anyone guess what each one means?

During

- Invite everyone to join in on "LOOP!" and "On it goes!", loud or whisper-quiet.
- Pause at the rip. "Uh-oh. What should Room 5 do?"
- Give Sam's quiet idea a moment of wait time.

After

- "Which link would you add first?"
- Play your first Add-One Chain round (teacher script, page 4).
- The story's back pages have more talk starters and games.

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The Add-One Chain Classroom Game Kit and the bonus story *More Talk, Less Tap*. First edition 2026 · Version 1.0 · September 2026.

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General classroom play ideas; not a program, assessment, screening tool or professional advice. Adults supervise all activities. The characters in the story are imaginary.



Play Before Pixels

More from Play Before Pixels

Talk, touch and play first, at school and at home.

For home, 0–5

100 Screen-Free Plays

100 easy, low-prep plays sorted by age, each with a talk line and a safety note. Paperback or printable PDF.

For families

Back-and-Forth Tally

A free one-page home game that celebrates everyday back-and-forth talk, with a fridge certificate. Coming soon.

For little siblings, 0–5

52 Play & Talk Cards

One simple play and one talk tip on every card, for the youngest talkers at home.



Your free bonus

Scan for a free printable of extra Add-One Chain topic cards and family talk games. We only ask for an email address: no child names, ever.

playbeforepixels.com/bonus/picture-more-talk-less-tap



Loved it? A short review and a photo of your chain (no children's faces or names, please) help other teachers find us.